A Funny Thing Happened on the Way to Fifth Period

By Jason Pizzarello

CHARACTERS: *Tommy, bookworm; Burp, head bully; Bugs, aspiring bully; Steve, friendly jock; Cora, Steve's girlfriend; Veronica, Steve's twin and a nerd with anger issues; Stephanie, lead actress; Chad, lead actor and Stephanie's boyfriend.*

******** Before School*******

At the lockers as TOMMY reorganizes his trapper keeper, a large bull of a kid, BURP, comes up behind him and politely taps him on the shoulder. TOMMY turns around and the bull lets a burp rip so loud and foul, you can almost smell yesterday's lunch. But this isn't the first time, and TOMMY handles it with grace. BURP smiles.)

TOMMY: **(Pg 141-160)** Lovely. *(Another bully, BUGS, not quite as menacing as BURP, but still with great potential, stands next to him and claps. BURP takes a bow)* Let me guess, you had a burrito and a slurpee for breakfast.

BURP: Cherry slurpee. That counts as a fruit. *(burps)* Well, enough chit chat. Where's my homework for first period?

TOMMY: ***Your*** homework? I don't know, where did you put it?

BURP: Where did ***you*** put it? I didn't do it. You did. You did ***my*** homework.

TOMMY: I only did ***my*** homework. *(takes out the homework)* See.

BURP: *(he snatches it away)* So you ***did*** do my homework.

TOMMY: C'mon, Burp. Give it back.

BURP: Nice chattin' with you, Tommy. See ya in class. *(As he exits, BURP burps while holding his fist in the air)*

INTRODUCTION

School hallways are delicate ecosystems filled with bullies, nerds, jocks and (sings) theatre kids! So when Tommy, mild-mannered techie and professional problem-solver, gets pushed around by Burp and his not-so-bright protégé, Bugs . . . he does what any reasonable teenager would do – comes up with a solution! This selection is a fast-paced hallway comedy about survival, social hierarchy, and the power of lying with confidence. Because all teen-agers know: if you can't be popular . . . Be convincing.

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TOMMY: *(BUGS is about to follow, but TOMMY stops him)* Hey Bugs, can you wait a second?

BUGS: For you? Three.

TOMMY: Next year, I was thinking . . . He's your mentor, everyone knows you're bound to follow in his footsteps. It's called destiny.

BUGS: It's called Burp. Maybe if you learned his name he wouldn't be so hard on you.

TOMMY: Right. What I'm trying to say is, next year, when you take over this hallway as lead bully, you don't have to be a bully like him. You can be a nice bully.

BUGS: I don't think you understand the concept of bullying.

TOMMY: This is your chance to revolutionize the field of bullying. You can be a pioneer.

BUGS: Like Davy Crocket?*(excited)* The other night my dad caught a raccoon --

TOMMY: Bugs, Bugs. I'm sure it was a lovely family dinner, but we're getting off topic. *(bell rings)* Just think about what I'm saying. Let's work together. There's gotta be something I can do for you to break this viscous cycle of bullying. *(STEPHANIE walks in singing a little show tune) (BUGS is enamored with her)*

STEPHANIE: Hey Tommy. Great job working the spotlight in last night's performance. You really knew how to keep it right on me. You're a peach of a techie, Tommy. *(STEPHANIE heads off)*

TOMMY: *(TOMMY watches BUGS watching STEPHANIE)* Bugs, Bugs, you all right?

BUGS: Stephanie Mezaluna. She could make a sheep throw himself to the wolves. She could make a shark swim backwards.

TOMMY: You like her huh? You wanna marry her? You wanna have little bug children?

BUGS: No, I just wanna take her to the prom. I asked Alice the lunch lady. But apparently she doesn't leave the cafeteria.

TOMMY: Too bad you already need your tickets to the prom. Today's the deadline. End of lunch. By fifth period.

BUGS: So that's our deadline.

TOMMY: Our deadline?

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BUGS: *(dramatic beat)* If you don't get me a date for the prom with Stephanie Mezaluna by fifth period, I will make the rest of your pathetic high school career a living nerd hell.

TOMMY: Here's your problem. You can't date Stephanie Mezaluna. She only dates actors. *Lead actors.* Are you a *lead* actor?

BUGS: Just make it happen. Your future alive self depends on it.

TOMMY: You mean "my life depends on it"? *(STEPHANIE returns to her locker)*

BUGS: She's right there.

TOMMY: *(Tommy reluctantly approaches STEPHANIE)* Ha...ha... Hi. *(whispers in her ear)*

STEPHANIE: You want me to go to the prom with Bugs? *(they look over at BUGS and catch him eating something from his hair)* Why would I do that? Unless, like, the world is ending. Or he's a famous actor or something.

TOMMY: Actually. I shouldn't really be saying this ... but he's . . . a professional actor.

STEPHANIE: Yeah right. How could he be? He's not even in any of the school plays.

TOMMY: He only acts in New York. His agent won't let him act in school plays. It might ... hurt his career. His agent is very strict when it comes to parts.

STEPHANIE: Who's his agent?

TOMMY: His agent's name? Uh ... Kris ... tooff ... Baba ... balooch. Kristoff Bababalooch. You've probably heard of him.

STEPHANIE: Yeah, totally. He's supposed to be really strict.

TOMMY: Yeah, that's him. He's Croatian. *(bell rings. STEPHANIE exits)*

BUGS: *(BUGS pulls TOMMY aside)* So are we set?

TOMMY: Not yet. But I think she's warming to the idea. One thing though. . . and this isn't a big deal at all. . . I kinda told her you were a professional actor. So brush up on your Shakespeare.

BUGS: Shakespeare is not a problem. *To not be, or to not be. . . is the same question.*

******** After First Period*******

TOMMY: Just be yourself. But be a professional actor from New York. *(TOMMY pulls out a fedora)* Here. Wear this.

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BUGS: Am I an actor working for the mob?

TOMMY: It'll add a little persona, a little mystique. *(They approach STEPHANIE. Suave-like, BUGS leans against her locker without saying anything)*

STEPHANIE: Oh. Hi . . . Bugs.

BUGS: *(BUGS tips his hat)* Hiya, sweetheart.

STEPHANIE: Tommy mentioned Kristoff Bababalooch might make it to our school play.

BUGS: Chrissy Baba-who?

STEPHANIE: Kristoff Bababalooch. Your agent.

BUGS: Oh ... right, that guy. Outta sight outta mind you know? Oh sure, he'll come. If you want him to. He loves that kinda junk. I mean he loves theater. I could probably get him to come today. I mean the guy is at my beck and call, ya know?

STEPHANIE: *(laughs nervously)* I should go tell the rest of the cast. This is so amazing!

BUGS: Sure, whatever. *(STEPHANIE runs out) (BUGS, as cool as he can, saunters quickly over to TOMMY)* I need an agent!

TOMMY: You have one. Kristoff Bababalooch.

BUGS: Right. I need him. To come to school. Today. I told her he could and now she thinks he's coming here and I need him to seal this deal and this is all your fault and I can't believe I just talked to Stephanie Mezaluna for as long as I did and the hat worked perfectly.

TOMMY: Okay-just calm down. Bugs, calm down. *(thinks)* Go find me a suit. The nicest suit you can find.

BUGS: A suit. For your funeral?

TOMMY: Maybe. Find Shelly in the costume shop, tell her I sent you. C'mon-go! *(BUGS nods and runs off) (TOMMY stops STEVE at his locker)*

TOMMY: Steve, I need a favor.

STEVE: I already told you I can't make you cool. It's just impossible.

TOMMY: Forget about that. I need you to pretend you're a talent agent from New York named Kristoff Bababalooch who represents Bugs who is pretending to be a

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professional actor so he can get a date for the prom and you're the only person that looks over 20 in our school, so I need you to dress as Kristoff so I can win my freedom from bully tyranny next year. Okay?

STEVE: I'll do it under one condition. You get a date for my sister Veronica for the prom. If she doesn't have a date, my mom is making me take her. She wants to go with Chad Glamorville.

TOMMY: But he's dating Stephanie Mezaluna.

STEVE: That's the deal.

TOMMY .... Actually this may work out. *(they shake; STEVE takes off) (bell rings)*

CHAD: *(walking down the hall, holding a script, rehearsing his lines)* And that is why, Mama, I ain't ever gonna let nothin' happen to our hogs. Nothin'!

TOMMY: Hey, I need to talk to you about something very important. You need to take Veronica Jettlebaum to prom.

CHAD: Veronica Jettlebaum? What are you, sick?

TOMMY: No ... but she is. It's Veronica's dying wish to go to the prom. But no one will go with her.

CHAD: What do you mean her ***dying*** wish? Is she really sick?

TOMMY: No, she has a rare disease. It's her ... her muscles ... are turning inside out. It's a very rare condition. She only has 3 weeks to live. It's a tragedy. A *Shakespearean* tragedy. You know all about those I'm sure.

CHAD: I have a background in the classics, yes.

TOMMY: Then you're the only one who can play this heroic role. It's only for *lead* actors.

CHAD: Like me.

TOMMY: Every great actor has their charity. Brad Pitt, Sean Penn, Keanu Reeves ... Have you found yours yet?

CHAD: No . . . I haven't. Shoot! I need a charity.

TOMMY: Make Veronica Jettlebaum your charity. Take her to the prom. *(bell rings)*

CHAD .... Okay, I'll do it. I'm sure Stephanie will understand. It's for our craft. *(TOMMY and*

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CHAD shake and head separate ways)

******** After Third Period*****

TOMMY: *(bell rings. TOMMY goes immediately to STEVE)* We're all set. Veronica has a date to go to the prom with Chad Glamorville.

STEVE: Well, that was easy.

TOMMY: I still need you to look and act like a believable talent agent from New York. He's from a Croatian island, okay? Shelly is waiting for you in the costume shop. I need you as Kristoff Bababalooch in this hallway by next period. *(STEVE hurries off and runs into VERONICA)* Veronica! Good news. We don't have to go to the prom together.

VERONICA: I told you I'd only go with Chad Glamorville.

STEVE: And you are. Talk to Tommy. *(STEVE runs out. VERONICA approaches TOMMY)*

VERONICA: Steve said-

TOMMY: Yes, Chad Glamorville. And you. And the prom. There's only one catch . . . you're dying. Not ***really*** dying. Just ***fake*** dying.

VERONICA: What am I dying of?

TOMMY: Here I made a list. *(hands her several sheets of paper. She flips through it)*

VERONICA: And if I'm dying of all these things, he agreed to go with me?

TOMMY: He has a very big heart. Now read through it. You gotta play that part.

VERONICA: Okay, if it's for Chad Glamorville, it's worth it. *(VERONICA heads off) (BUGS confronts TOMMY)*

BUGS: What was that all about?

TOMMY: It's all part of the plan. *(STEPHANIE confronts BUGS and TOMMY)*

STEPHANIE: I thought you said your agent was coming. Where is he?

BUGS: I just talked to him. He's on his way. I'll go try his cell again. *(BUGS leaves)*

STEPHANIE: Why would he be in town?

TOMMY: He's scouting ... for talent. If he comes here, will you go with Bugs to the prom?

STEPHANIE: If a New York agent walks down this hall, I will go to the prom with Bugs. And if he doesn't, I'll make sure you never get a date in this school again.

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TOMMY: I don't get any now, so . . . it's a deal. *(they shake; STEPHANIE exits)*

********After 4th Period ******** *(Bell rings)*

CHAD: *(CHAD pulls TOMMY aside)* The gown Veronica wears to the prom isn't going to be like a hospital gown is it? Because I already rented my tux and we have to match.

TOMMY: Of course not. It's not like she wears a hospital gown to school. *(VERONICA enters in a hospital gown. She coughs dramatically and does an exaggerated limping walk)*

CHAD: Uh . . . hi . . . Veronica. Sorry to hear you're sick. Are you going to be okay?

VERONICA: Ha, ha. You're cute. All I ever wanted was to be treated ... *(cough, cough)* ... like a normal teenager.

STEPHANIE: *(STEPHANIE enters)* So guys, where's Kristoff?

STEVE: *(STEVE enters as Kristoff Bababalooch, the sleazy New York super-agent. He speaks with a slightly ambiguous European accent)* Bugs, baby! Be wit you in a hot minute.

BUGS: *(Aside to TOMMY)* Who's that?

TOMMY: *(Aside)* That's your agent, you nitwit.

STEVE: *(to VERONICA)* Who are you? You've got a great look. Sick is very "in" right now. Here's my card. *(then approaches BUGS)* There he is. You bug-eater-you.

BUGS: *(Immediately playing the part)* Kristoff! So good of you to come. *(STEVE air kisses BUGS on both cheeks)* Kristoff, I'd like you to meet a very talented actress... Kristoff, this is Stephanie Mezaluna.

STEPHANIE: It's a pleasure to meet you, Mr. Bababalooch. *(STEVE air kisses her on both cheeks)*

TOMMY: Stephanie and Bugs are going to the prom together, isn't that, right, Stephanie?

STEPHANIE: Oh...right. That's...right.

STEVE: That's great, great. Crazy kids. I remember my prom. It was inside a volcano. Because I'm from an island or something. We used to play futbol with rotten pineapples coated in pig grease. *(TOMMY signals him to stop talking)* Well . . . I gotta get going. Send me your headshots. *(CORA enters looks at STEVE strangely)*

STEVE: Bugs, why is this strange girl staring at me? Please ask her to leave.

TOMMY: *(pulls CORA aside)* Cora, get out of here. You're gonna ruin the whole thing.

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CORA: Is that Steve?

TOMMY: Of course it is. *(takes a deep breath)* He's playing a talent agent, who represents Bugs who's pretending to be a famous actor to impress Stephanie in exchange for my freedom from his bullying, in exchange for me getting a date with Chad Glamorville, for Veronica who's pretending to be sick, so Steve is free to go to the prom with you.

CORA: *(beat)* Aw, that's sweet. *(exits)*

TOMMY: It worked! Looks like things may finally be looking up for me.

BURP: *(enters with a vulgar burp)* If I could have your attention. I have some exciting news for all of you. Due to my extraordinary lack of academic efforts, you will be delighted to know that I will be gracing you with my presence again next year.

TOMMY: You're staying back ... again?

BUGS: Looks like things are finally looking up for you.

TOMMY: Burp, maybe we can work something out. I've done wonders for the people around here. *(TOMMY puts his arm around BURP and they walk out in negotiations)*

OFF STAGE VOICE: Last chance for prom tickets! Last chance!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2011 National Qualifier
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AUTHOR NOTES: *Feel free to change the reference to "high school" to "middle school" and the "prom" to the "dance" or "school dance." Any casting decisions that require characters to change gender are fine.*

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